NF AUDIO TOOLS

NF – STRESSOR

REDLINE / 1% THD

Owner's Manual

OVERVIEW

NF – Stressor is a faithful, from-scratch emulation of a classic opto/FET rack compressor, built as a tall, narrow vertical strip inspired by outboard hardware. It covers the full signature behaviour of the original design: a fixed internal threshold driven by the INPUT knob, a true discrete OPTO mode tied to the RATIO 10:1 position, a hard-knee "NUKE" ratio stage, and independent character (distortion) switches.

Everything on the panel mirrors real hardware conventions — there is no dedicated THRESHOLD knob; instead, INPUT drives your signal harder or softer against a fixed internal reference, exactly like the classic units this plugin is inspired by.

> Tip: because there's no threshold control, gain reduction is driven entirely by how hard you push INPUT. Start low and raise it until the GR meter starts moving.

Formats

- macOS: VST3 and Audio Unit (AU), Intel and Apple Silicon.
- Windows: VST3, 64-bit.

INSTALLATION

macOS

Run the NF – Stressor installer package and follow the prompts. It installs VST3, AU and the bilingual PDF manual into the standard system-wide folders:

- **VST3**: `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/`
- **AU**: `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/`

Windows

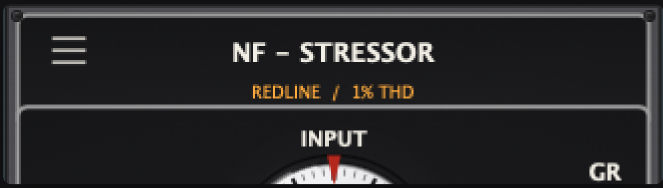
Run the NF - Stressor installer and follow the wizard. It installs the VST3 into the standard system-wide folder:

- **VST3**: `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\`

> After installing, rescan plug-ins in your DAW if it doesn't pick up NF – Stressor automatically.

INTERFACE TOUR

The panel is a single vertical strip, read top to bottom: brand plate at the top, the four main knobs with the OPTO light and gain-reduction ladder meter beside them, the RATIO row, the DETECTOR/AUDIO character switches, and finally MIX with the NUKE and BYPASS buttons stacked in the same column.



The hamburger icon (top-left) opens the preset menu. Double-clicking the brand plate itself, or the bare top-left corner of the chassis, snaps the window back to its default size — handy after resizing it larger for detail work.

INPUT, ATTACK, RELEASE and OUTPUT, each with a rotating numbered dial (0–10) and a fixed red index mark at the top. The ladder of LEDs on the right shows live gain reduction in dB.

MAIN CONTROLS

INPUT

Drives the signal into the compressor's fixed internal threshold. There is no separate threshold control — turning INPUT up pushes the signal harder against that reference, increasing gain reduction.

ATTACK

Sets how quickly the compressor reacts to a transient, from a fast FET-like response at the SLOW-labelled end of its travel to a much slower response toward the FAST-labelled end — small tick marks beside the knob mark exactly which end is which.

RELEASE

Sets how quickly gain reduction lets go after the signal drops, from a fast release at the FAST-labelled end of its travel to a slow one toward the SLOW-labelled end.

> OPTO mode: selecting RATIO 10:1 (or clicking the OPTO light itself) engages it, snapping ATTACK to 10 and RELEASE to 0 — the panel's own “OPTO” detent, exactly like the hardware's end-of-travel position. Both knobs stay fully interactive the whole time: dragging either one away from that position turns the OPTO light back off (RATIO can stay at 10:1 — the light always reflects what the engine is actually doing, never just where RATIO is set). While genuinely engaged, RELEASE becomes program-dependent: a short, shallow hit recovers quickly, while a deep or sustained one lets go progressively more slowly, smoothly, up to several seconds — never in audible steps. Double-click the OPTO light for a hard exit back to whichever RATIO you were on before.

OPTO engaged: RATIO at 10:1, ATTACK snapped to 10, RELEASE snapped to 0, the light lit beside ATTACK.

OUTPUT

Trims the final output level after compression, character shaping and mix.

RATIO

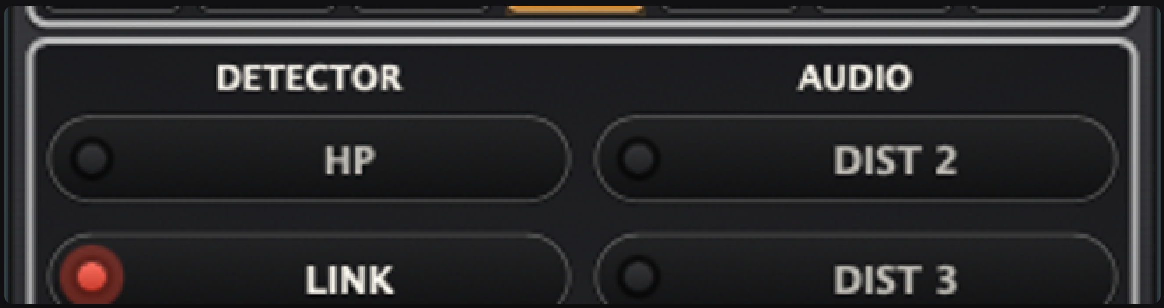
Selects the compression ratio. 1:1 through 6:1 behave as classic soft-knee compression. 10:1 and 20:1 engage an extra “redline” stage: a harder knee and a touch more drive into the character stage, matching the tagline lighting up amber. 10:1 is also the panel's dedicated OPTO position — see OPTO mode above.

1:1	2:1	3:1	4:1	6:1	10:1	20:1
Soft-knee compression					Redline / harder knee	

> NUKE: a dedicated button, independent of RATIO, sharing NUKE/BYPASS's column above MIX. Engaging it layers a true brick-wall limiter on top of whatever ratio is dialled in — an effectively infinite ratio, a razor-thin knee, a near-instant catch regardless of the ATTACK knob, and extra harmonic bite. Use it when you need a hard ceiling, not just more compression.

NUKE engaged (blue) beside a driven MIX knob.

DETECTOR & AUDIO



DETECTOR

HP

Engages a fixed high-pass filter in the sidechain, so low end doesn't dominate the detector's decisions — useful on bass-heavy sources.

LINK

Links the detector across both channels of a stereo signal so gain reduction tracks together, avoiding image shift on stereo material.

AUDIO

DIST 2 / DIST 3

Two independent character switches shaping the tone of the compressed signal: DIST 2 alone gives an FET-ish, asymmetric edge; DIST 3 alone gives a smoother, more opto-ish drive; engaging both together gives a coloured, more aggressive “British” character.

DIST 2 and DIST 3 both engaged — the coloured “British” character.

MIX, BYPASS & NUKE

MIX

Blends dry and compressed (wet) signal, for parallel compression — keep the punch of the uncompressed signal while still catching peaks.

BYPASS

Disengages all processing. Sized and styled exactly like NUKE, sitting directly below it in the same column beside MIX. The LED and the word BYPASS blink together while engaged, so it's never ambiguous that the plugin is doing nothing.

NUKE and BYPASS, same size and style, stacked in the same column.

GAIN REDUCTION LADDER

A vertical LED ladder marked in dB (1 through 26) shows live gain reduction: green for light reduction, amber from 6 dB, red from 12 dB up — matching the NUKE/redline territory. The “GR” label sits directly above the first LED, and the whole ladder is positioned so its 4 dB step lines up with the OPTO light beside ATTACK.

“GR” directly over the first LED; the ladder shifted so its 4 dB step lines up with the OPTO light.

WINDOW & SHORTCUTS

Double-click any main knob

INPUT, ATTACK, RELEASE, OUTPUT and MIX all snap straight back to that parameter's own factory default the moment you double-click them — the same convention used by other Distressor-style plug-ins, so you never have to hunt for where a control started.

Double-click the logo / chassis corner

Double-clicking the “NF – STRESSOR” brand plate, or the bare top-left corner of the chassis, instantly resets the plug-in window to its default size — a quick way back after dragging the corner resizer larger for detail work. It only affects window size, never any parameter.

PRESETS

Click the hamburger icon in the top-left corner to open the preset menu:

The preset menu, with a saved preset ready to recall.

- **Default** — resets every control to its factory value.
- **Save Preset…** — writes the current settings to a preset file you name.
- **Load Preset…** — opens a preset file from anywhere on disk.

Any preset saved into the default presets folder also appears directly in this menu for one-click recall.

USAGE TIPS

- For vocals: moderate RATIO (3:1–4:1), ATTACK around the middle, or RATIO 10:1 for OPTO's natural, program-dependent release.
- For drum bus glue: LINK on, HP on to keep kick/bass from pumping the detector, RATIO 4:1–6:1.
- For aggressive drum room/parallel duty: push INPUT hard, RATIO 20:1, MIX under 50% to blend in the squashed signal under the dry track.
- Reach for NUKE only when you need a hard ceiling on top of your ratio — it's a limiter stage, not a subtler compression option.
- Double-click a knob any time you want to compare against its factory default without reaching for the preset menu.

CREDITS & VERSION

NF – Stressor is developed by NF Audio Tools. This manual and the plugin describe version V1.0.

NF – STRESSOR · V1.0